to just five seats, Nitish won just two, Kejriwal's AAP bagged only four seats, all of which came from Punjab.

The biggest defeat was of the Congress. The mighty party of the freedom movement was down to just forty-four seats, its worst ever performance. Not even the 1977 post-Emergency debacle had been this terrible. In all the states where there was a direct fight with the BJP, the Congress was demolished. An SMS joke doing the rounds suggested that if you travelled along the highway up north from Mumbai, the first Congress constituency you would touch was Amritsar!

The BJP, on the other hand, had quite remarkably won 282 seats on its own, the first instance of single-party majority since 1984. UP had been swept—a quite astonishing seventy-three of the eighty seats were in the BJP–Apna Dal kitty. The party won all the seats in Rajasthan and Gujarat, its alliance won forty-two of the forty-eight seats in Maharashtra and thirty-one of the forty in Bihar. Of the seventy seats where the polling percentage had gone up by more than 15 per cent, the BJP and its allies won as many as sixty-seven. On our map in the studio, north, west and central India had only one colour—and it was saffron.

This was a rout. If it was a T20 match, they might have called it off after just the first power play.

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Modi, as always, had got up very early that morning. If he was excited, he wasn't showing it. He was a bit like a CBSE topper who probably knew he was going to get cent per cent but was just waiting for a final confirmation. He did his usual morning meditation and had a very light breakfast before placing himself before the television screens. His team was providing him constant inputs by the minute. He, too, knew in the first two hours that it was all over.

'India has won!' his aide tweeted from his account. Even in victory, he hadn't forgotten the power of constant communication. Or of symbolism. A little after noon, he emerged from his residence and drove to meet his